

Four marks walked, four places named – and at the end of the chain, where the one who was to meet you should have stood, no one. Only a sealed packet wedged where you could not miss it, a hand you half-recognise scratched on the outside; and folded within, a single scrap of paper. N. is gone. Fled, or taken, or thinking better of the whole business – but gone. A go-between who melts away on the very night the city takes up arms is rarely one who simply chose to leave.

You had heard the city all the way here. Saint Dorothy's crowds parting for carts the carters swear are loaded with fireworks "for the feast" – yet the crates ride low and heavy, and the men beside them are not laughing. And under the masks the same talk keeps surfacing, again and again, if you let yourselves listen – and none of it kind to the Order whose business you carry. That the brothers lay their pound-toll on the city's own merchants and let their own kind off light; a lord who fleeces the very people he keeps. That salt and copper and amber all sit in the Order's fist, and a man who would trade must pay the brothers first for the right. That of a thousand knights there are three hundred left, if that – a garrison of a handful rattling about that great castle, a lord who can scarcely hold the town he claims. And, from an old soldier who spat as you passed: that the Grand Master sits in Marienburg and has not answered a letter in weeks – that the Order's own head has left this city to shift for itself.

The dispatch is still heavy in the bag, and it still has to reach the right hands before the eighth bell. With N. gone, the way is yours to find. You unfold his scrap – and beside it the packet has left you something to work from: three of the Order's men, sent about the town this morning, and the posts they kept.

THE MORNING'S MEN

Three of the Order's men were about the town this morning. Each was at one post, and each bore one thing. Work out who was where — and what each man carried.

Where each was posted, and the mark that place bears on your map:

- The Chelmno Gate — 
- The Komtur's seat, by the castle — 
- The chapel of St. Mary — 

The three: Heinrich · Konrad · Albrecht *What each man bore:* a ring of keys · a sealed dispatch · the Komtur's own seal

Heard about town this morning — every word of it true:

1. Heinrich locked the Chelmno Gate at dawn, and kept its keys on him the morning long.
2. The man at the chapel bore the dispatch, to be read out at the Mass.
3. Konrad has not set foot by the castle in a week.

Place all three, and for each you will have a name, a post, and the mark it bears. ONLY ONE OF THOSE THREE MARKS IS ON YOUR MAP. THAT IS WHERE YOU GO — AND NO OTHER. AND WHEN YOU STAND BEFORE THE MAN YOU WERE SENT TO, NAME TO HIM WHAT HE BORE THIS MORNING: THAT IS THE WORD SET FOR TODAY, AND BY IT HE WILL KNOW YOU FOR THE ORDER'S.

So you are on your own. A puzzle to point you at a door, a proud man behind it who will make you earn his trust, and the dispatch still heavy in the bag. Whoever N. was, he is gone — you are not. Three people, three errands. Work it out.